

HOPE FOR THE BEST, PREPARE FOR THE WORST

On my last trip to Switzerland, my stepfather, George, sat me down for a talk. “I’ve set aside some money for the last years of my life,” he said, “and I want every dime of it spent on keeping me in my home until I’m gone.” Who could blame him? George has worked hard his whole life, even during his retirement. He retired officially at 60, but even after that he worked as a full-time consultant for the government of the United Arab Emirates, then half time in Russia for the World Bank. He received a steady stream of assignments until, at 74, he finally put his foot down. Now he lives in a beautiful house in Geneva overlooking the lake. If he wants to stay there until they carry him out in a box, he’s earned that privilege.

But what if things don’t go according to plan? Switzerland has what many argue is the best health-care system in the world, yet even then the costs of long-term care are formidable. What if George is seriously injured or has a stroke? What happens if he needs a home health-care provider to be with him 24/7? Or if he has to be put on life support and hooked up to a bunch of machines? If any of these events were to occur, George would burn through his money fast.